

Episode 174: *Mawaru Penguindrum* Colour Design Notes Part 1

Happy New Year. I dropped manuscripts terribly last year - I apologise. That was all for *Mawaru Penguindrum*. Yes, *Mawaru Penguindrum*! Were you all watching?

Main broadcasting has ended, but Blu-ray and DVD are still coming! So...
Anyway.

Finally starting today! *Mawaru Penguindrum* colour design notes. There must be people secretly waiting for this! ...I'd like to think so. Starting anyway.

Episode 1: The Bell of Fate Rings

Storyboard: Ikuhara Kunihiko, Direction: Nakamura Akiko, Colour Direction (色指定): Tsujita Kunio

First, Episode 1. Episode 1 is important anyway. We have to properly present "this is what we're doing!" first. Story, direction, animation too, but altogether showing "screen basics." This becomes Episode 1's most important point. For *Mawaru Penguindrum*, we considered the Takakura house living room and kitchen scenes as "screen basics."

The first art boards submitted were Episode 1's opening bed, Takakura house living room, and kitchen. The bed is also an important key scene, but more of a place to show imagistically. The centre of acting is naturally Takakura house daily acting. Firmly deciding and creating this, burning this visual balance into viewers' minds is important.

So *Mawaru Penguindrum*'s main character colours were decided on this living room background board.

Director Ikuhara's order was "clear feeling." My image was the same direction - being careful not to become ambiguous by over-aiming or look dirty by lowering saturation.

And the delivered art board's vividness and wonderful hand-drawn density feeling. "Good!" I began creating colours with good motivation.

Kanba and Shoma's hair colours - red and blue directions - were from the director. Since they were supposedly "twins," I tried creating "twin-ness" by matching and unifying eye colours. But actually at this point, though they were "brothers" and "siblings," there was "actually..." so I hoped for good misleading visuals and colours.

For Himari, I initially considered darker black-ish or dark brown hair with sickly pale skin, but the director said "more fragile feeling..." so hair became light, and we modified hair main lines to bright, light brown. Bright, fragile-feeling skin and hair, white-based blouse with vivid light blue skirt. This light blue - I thought slightly more subdued might be good, but the director demanded vividness "to the limit" for that balance. Light blue tends to develop intensely on HD screens, so quite nerve-wracking colours. And boots.

These boots were another struggle. Sheepskin-like boot image was immovable from the start, but basic main line colours made outline lines too strong for boot colours, creating "unbeautiful" balance. So ultimately, I decided to brighten boot main line colours too. Colour tracing for hair (eyebrows) plus boot main lines. This is quite troublesome in colouring work. Certainly becomes difficult, but this good balance was non-negotiable. So I decided to go with this colour tracing.

When general colour balance was decided, "Tsujita-kun, a little consultation..." said Director Ikuhara. "Could we make the eye feeling more Hoshino-san-like?" This time, character concepts were requested from Hoshino Lily-san, and the consultation was whether we could put Hoshino-san's colour illustration atmosphere into main story visuals. Hoshino-san's drawn eyes have dark pupils with deep, beautiful, sexy bleeding. I was conscious of that, but Nishii-san's animation character artwork details alone didn't work well. But adding more complex details and highlights to artwork itself might cause painful results if character animation wavered.

So what to do? Slightly tighter and darker than initially decided, plus one more processing. Using eye pupil colours, adding gradation brushes to eyes that gradually darken upward. We asked photography staff to add this. This was how I compiled it as a compromise. Uniformly adding this processing to main characters. Naturally, some cuts have additional ingenuity.

Characters were roughly decided like this.

Oh yes, penguins (laugh). Penguins are naturally that colour (laugh). I tried making blackish-coloured ones too, but they were lacklustre. Long ago there was a Suntory commercial campaign called "Penguin's Bar" with penguins this blue. That colour image seems imprinted on both me and Director Ikuhara (laugh). Incidentally, the blackish penguin colour I tried making was later inherited by Esmeralda.

Like that, Episode 1 main story.

As written earlier, the episode presents "screen basics" of "this is what we're doing!" I thought it important to impress important visuals for stories developing over 2 cours (all 24 episodes) in the first episode. So Episode 1 basically allocated more "normal" coloured scenes. Also, firmly showing important scenes (special colouring scenes) appearing throughout at key points. These two points were first important.

So basic "Takakura house living room," subway interiors, aquarium, souvenir shops were firmly shown in "normal colours." Conversely, hospital examination room's bluish scenes, scenes where Himari stops breathing, and morgue's strong evening scenes were also created with colours to remain strongly impressive. Anyway, screen tempo and contrast. I intended to avoid brightness changes and shadows by time of day in Episode 1 as much as possible, but naturally rain scenes had brightness adjustments matching backgrounds.

My series-wide design plan was to build relatively natural-looking colour design for the first half cour, then deploy various tricky colour usage from when the story begins moving significantly in the middle. It's 2 cours after all. First, creating screen balance that lets stories smoothly enter viewers was essential.

Well, Episode 1 was exciting anyway. Just enjoyable. How will we proceed? And ah, so this is how the animation becomes! Colour direction input and colouring completion inspection work were endlessly fun. Oh yes, as Episode 1's small detail, the commuter pass holder delivered to #2 - that colour is my actually used commuter pass holder (laugh). I was commuting to Mitaka's Brain's Base with that pass holder and Suica commuter pass (laugh). When you do colour direction yourself, such fun is possible - enjoyable. Self-satisfaction though (laugh).

Even so, those two boys... (bitter laugh). Those were colours decided in the moment - if I'd known from the start, I would have decided more carefully (bitter laugh).

According to records, this Episode 1's art meeting was held at the end of November the year before last (2010). Broadcast start was next summer, so about half a year before. But actually at this point, storyboards weren't completed. Well, were they tentatively done? Either way, we couldn't discuss some parts. Yes, that bank scene where Princess of Crystal appears.

(12.01.10)